

Chapter 98-3

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The breakfast shop was packed with people. Four of them gathered around a small table.

Xu Qingzhu spoke first. "I've recently fallen in love with xiaolongbao.¹ Is that okay with everyone?"

Liang Shi immediately agreed. "I'll have the mushroom filling."

Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui just nodded, leaving the ordering to Xu Qingzhu.

Clearly, Xu Qingzhu hadn't been to places like this very often, but she just had this confidence that could command the whole room, giving people the illusion that she had been here many times and was extremely familiar with this kind of shop.

Seeing this, what else could Shen Hui not understand?

So they had been putting on an act for her earlier. No wonder every word had been a provocation.

Tsk.

Shen Hui sneered inwardly. Only after they sat down did Xu Qingzhu say, "Let me introduce myself first. I'm Xu Qingzhu. This is my wife, Liang Shi. I'm an Omega, and Dr. Zhao and I are... friends, I suppose."

The introduction was crystal clear.

Normal people wouldn't introduce their secondary gender when meeting someone.

Shen Hui looked at Liang Shi and smiled with her arms crossed. "And you? Miss Liang."

Liang Shi: "....."

She cleared her throat softly and braced herself to introduce herself. "I'm Liang Shi. This is my wife next to me. I'm an Alpha, and Zhao Xuning and I....."

Liang Shi paused. A belated sense of shame welled up in her heart. Especially facing the dual pressure of Shen Hui's and Xu Qingzhu's gazes, she chose to apologize first. "I'm sorry. I was just acting earlier. Zhao Xuning and I are purely friends—as pure as pure can be."

"Miss Liang's attitude toward friends is truly admirable." Shen Hui's voice was flat, revealing neither joy nor anger. "To be able to sacrifice this much for a friend—impressive."

Liang Shi: "....."

She felt like Shen Hui was insulting her, but she had no evidence.

Moreover, that sentence was very similar to Xu Qingzhu's style. It wouldn't feel out of place at all if Xu Qingzhu had said it.

"It's because I noticed there still seemed to be a little spark between you two." Liang Shi explained. "So I wanted to give you a little push."

Shen Hui said coldly, "You imagined it."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning sat to the side without speaking.

On this ordinary morning, it was the first time Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui had eaten breakfast together in three hundred days.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu sat across from the two of them. The breakfast shop was filled with the fragrance of congee. Steam rose and lingered in the air. People coming and going were chatting and laughing. The four of them ate their meal quietly.

Shen Hui finished first. Zhao Xuning frowned from beside her. "You're only eating this much?"

"Not hungry." Shen Hui answered.

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together and picked up another one for her with her chopsticks.

When Shen Hui looked over, Zhao Xuning said softly, "Shen Hui, one last one."

This sentence took Shen Hui back to their university days. Neither she nor Zhao Xuning knew how to cook, and the two of them really weren't diligent enough to eat breakfast every day.

If they had been up late the night before, or if Zhao Xuning had been particularly rough with her, Shen Hui would definitely be hungry the next morning.

Back when they had just gotten together, whenever Shen Hui said she wanted breakfast, Zhao Xuning would insist on holding her for another round. The two of them always had endless energy in that room.

After they were done, Zhao Xuning would hold her and sleep, saying they'd go eat after waking up.

Either way, Shen Hui could never get her breakfast.

Then one time, when Zhao Xuning did it again, Shen Hui cried from hunger.

Zhao Xuning was asleep when she felt tears falling on her face. She wiped at them, only to discover that Shen Hui was crying.

Her voice just after waking was unbearably hoarse. She held Shen Hui in her arms, kissed her face, her hand gently caressing her waist, and asked softly, "Wife, why are you crying?"

Shen Hui wouldn't let her hold her or kiss her. She cried with hiccuping sobs. "I'm hungry."

Zhao Xuning said, "If you're hungry, just order delivery."

"I want dumplings from Cafeteria Seven."² Shen Hui said.

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The cafeteria didn't do delivery.

Back then, Zhao Xuning was so lazy. She absolutely didn't want to get out of bed to go to the cafeteria to buy food.

But Shen Hui's tears seemed endless. She said she wanted dumplings from Cafeteria Seven—she wanted those specific dumplings and nothing else would do.

Zhao Xuning grew impatient and snapped at her, "Why are you being so difficult?"

Shen Hui was stunned at that moment.

Footnotes:

¹ Xiaolongbao (小籠包): A type of Chinese steamed bun (dumpling) traditionally from Shanghai and the surrounding Jiangnan region. They are known for containing hot soup inside along with the meat filling, and are typically served in bamboo steaming baskets.

² "Cafeteria Seven" (七食堂): Chinese universities typically have multiple cafeterias on campus, often numbered. Students usually develop preferences for specific cafeterias based on their food quality or specialty dishes.